

CHAPTER 1

GETTING STARTED

Have you ever wondered why some people seem to have the ability to accomplish a lot? They know where they are headed and exude an enviable confidence. Effective goal setting is one of their keys to success. You may be working very hard at what you do, but without setting goals you'll find that your hard work doesn't yield meaningful results.

Remember *Alice in Wonderland*? At one point in the story, Alice stops at the crossroads to ask the Cheshire Cat which road to take. He responds by asking where she wants to go. When she tells him that she "doesn't much care where," he replies, "then it doesn't matter which way you go." As a result, she wanders aimlessly in her travels.

Like Alice, we often travel the road of life without a specific direction or goal. Few of us make goal setting a priority. In fact, studies have shown that most people either do not know what they want from life or, if they do, have no plans for realizing their dreams. Only a small percentage of people have specific, well-defined goals. And people who most frequently reach their goals are those who write them down and develop the plans to reach them.

Take a moment to consider why writing down your goals makes such a significant difference in ultimate performance. Why do you think that writing down one's goals is so important?

If your response included the idea that goal achievers record their goals so that they can read them, absorb them, and plan for them, then you are on the right track. People who achieve their goals take an active role in achieving them. They write them down, and then plan for their achievement. This chapter considers ten guidelines for evaluating and writing down your goals. If you follow these guidelines, you will establish your goals in a way that nearly guarantees your effort will be rewarded. Time and again, your reward is successful goal achievement.

Before learning the ten guidelines for effective goal setting, take a few minutes to identify two of your goals—they can be anything as long as they are meaningful to you—and write them down. Then, complete the self-audit, which identifies ten elements for effective goal setting. Evaluate the extent to which you use these ideas when developing your goals.

Your Goals

1. _____
2. _____

Now complete the self-audit on page 5 by checking either “Nearly Always,” “Sometimes,” or “Rarely” for each statement.

TEN GUIDELINES THAT REALLY WORK

The questions you just answered identify ten guidelines for effective goal setting. Using these ideas ensures that you establish goals that can be accomplished. The ten guidelines are:

1. **Effective goals are written.** Many of us daydream about what we would like to accomplish. But how many of us pick up a pen and write down those things we most want to achieve? Once a dream is committed to paper, it becomes concrete. Your dream is given a sense of reality. Writing down your goals is a first step toward achieving them.

SELF-AUDIT FOR GOAL SETTING

	Nearly Always	Sometimes	Rarely
1. When I set a goal, I write it down.	_____	_____	_____
2. I describe my goal in specific, measurable terms.	_____	_____	_____
3. I often visualize my goals.	_____	_____	_____
4. My goals are achievable.	_____	_____	_____
5. I set realistic deadlines for completing my goals.	_____	_____	_____
6. I break a large goal into manageable units.	_____	_____	_____
7. I look for the potential problems that may keep me from reaching my goals.	_____	_____	_____
8. I take action to remove or minimize those potential problems.	_____	_____	_____
9. I review progress toward my goals on a regular basis.	_____	_____	_____
10. I know the personal rewards of reaching my goals.	_____	_____	_____

Assess your responses by counting the number of times you responded “Nearly Always” and multiply that number by 3. Multiply the number of times you responded “Sometimes” by 2, and the number of times you responded “Rarely” by 1. Then add the resulting three numbers for a total score.

Nearly Always _____ (number of responses) $\times$ 3 = _____

Sometimes _____ (number of responses) $\times$ 2 = _____

Rarely _____ (number of responses) $\times$ 1 = _____

GRAND TOTAL = _____

Analyzing Your Score

Score of:

24–30	Excellent job of setting effective goals. If you find that you do an excellent job of setting goals, but you feel you could be more successful in reaching them, then Chapter 2 may be especially meaningful for you.
18–23	You are on your way to achieving effective goal setting. Take another look at the statements where your responses were less than “Nearly Always.” These are the areas for additional concentration.
Below 18	There are several areas in which you can improve your goal setting. In setting the goal of reading and using this book, you are becoming a more effective goal setter.

2. Effective goals are written in specific, measurable terms. If you write your goal in specific terms, then you probably have expressed it in a measurable way. A goal needs to be measurable so that your progress can be evaluated and so that you will know when you have achieved your goal. For instance, you may think about learning a new computer software package. But only when you describe your goal as “taking a class in WordPerfect between March and June and spending six to eight hours a week to learn its applications to my job” will you have a definable, measurable goal.

EXAMPLES OF MEASURABLE GOALS

- By April 1, I will have my taxes completed and ready to be mailed.
 - This week I will make fifteen sales calls and close on four of them.
 - We will hire a new secretary within two weeks.
-

3. Effective goals can be visualized. Picture yourself reaching your goal. Picture the result, the moment, and your feelings. Much of our energy for reaching goals comes from a desire to attain them. Usually, the more you desire something, the harder you will work toward achieving it. For example, a sales rep has won several awards. He accomplishes his extraordinary sales goals by visualizing his reward of receiving the plaque and winning the trip each year. He says, “I can see myself walking across the stage, being congratulated by the CEO, and enjoying my moment in the spotlight. When I’m having a slow day, I just visualize the result that I want, and it renews my energy.”

Victor Frankl is a Viennese psychologist and survivor of a World War II concentration camp. In his book *Man's Search for Meaning*, Frankl describes people who were able to visualize their goals for living and, consequently, were able to withstand the tortures of their circumstances. He maintains that people who had no purpose died quickly; those who kept an eye on their goals were more likely to survive.

4. Effective goals are achievable. Goals need to challenge your skills and abilities, without discouraging your effort and performance. For example, when initially implementing a quality management program, companies do not usually target the highly acclaimed and highly competitive Malcolm Baldrige National Quality Award as their first goal. Instead, they establish less stringent quality goals at first so that work teams can experience success in reaching those more realistic goals. As competency, success, and confidence grow, work teams may then decide to stretch for the higher goal.

5. Effective goals have realistic deadlines. Goals need a schedule. You are more likely to take action when you set a realistic time frame for accomplishing your goal. Schedule enough time to reach the goal, but not so much time that you lose interest in it. How many people have you heard say they need a vacation from their work but don't get around to taking one? A far higher percentage of people meet their goal when they record their specific intentions. "I will plan a vacation for the second week in March and arrangements will be settled by January 15."

6. Effective goals are manageable. Sometimes a goal can seem overwhelming because of its size. But if it is divided into smaller components, then it becomes easier to manage and is achievable. To hear your boss say that he wants you to open seventy-two accounts this year may sound unrealistic, but if you think of it in terms of six accounts each month, then the goal is more manageable.

7. Effective goals are analyzed for their potential problems. As you establish a goal, consider the steps you must take to accomplish it. Analyze the goal for potential problems that might keep you from reaching it. If a goal initially is considered in terms of what could go wrong, then you can take action to resolve or minimize problems before they occur. Critical thinking helps you cover all the angles and stay on the path toward achieving your goal.

ANALYZE YOUR GOAL FOR POTENTIAL PROBLEMS

What could go wrong with the goal of "Meeting a Project Deadline"?

1. A member on the project team does not complete his or her part on time.
 2. A needed piece of equipment may break down (e.g., word processor).
 3. Unexpected tasks related to the project may arise.
 4. The supervisor may not like the format of the final result.
-

8. Effective goals require action to eliminate or minimize the consequences of potential problems. This is the follow-through for identifying potential problems. At this point, you identify the *action* that is required to either remove the cause of the problem or minimize its consequences. For example, an unproductive team member could be the cause of a potential problem. Eliminate the problem by removing the unproductive member from the team. Other potential problems, however, can be dealt with only by minimizing their impact. For example, in manufacturing there is often a potential for equipment breakdown. Minimize the consequences by providing regular maintenance or having backup equipment available.

9. Effective goals include a regular review of progress. A periodic review of your goals will help ensure that they continue to be realistic, timely, and relevant. Consider, for example, the human resources director who, only twelve credit hours and a dissertation away from her doctorate, decided to quit. How could she invest the time, money, and energy to get so far toward a goal and then quit? After serious review of her career, family, and financial goals, she realized that the degree did not hold the promise it once had. Obtaining a doctorate was no longer a relevant goal for her life circumstances and interests.

10. Effective goals yield rewards that are of value to you. We stay motivated to work toward our goals when we know and desire the resulting rewards, whatever they may be. As you establish each goal, identify at least one meaningful reward for yourself. It may be money, recognition, a day off, or the quiet pleasure you feel for a job done well. Your reward can be anything of value to you, something that motivates your effort to accomplish the goal. Without recognizing specific benefits that accrue as a result of your efforts, the probability of reaching that goal decreases.

With these ten points in mind, review the two goals you wrote on page 4. Consider the extent to which you can use the ten guidelines just discussed.

Which of the guidelines are the most difficult for you to use?

Keeping the guidelines in mind, how would you rewrite your goals?

Goals provide direction for your life; they focus your activities. Goals are the points on your roadmap where you can apply your talents and energies. Without well-constructed goals, your life is governed by whim or the urgency of the moment. But effective goals will provide

you with the internal control to make things happen the way you want them to.

DO YOUR GOALS SHOW YOU THE WAY?

At the beginning of this chapter, you listed two goals to jump-start your thinking. Then you were given ten guidelines to help you consider those goals in a more systematic way. For the next exercise, review the areas of life listed next for which effective goal setting is critical. Check those areas for which you already have significant goals. Then write down those goals using the worksheet. If you need to, refer to the goal-setting guidelines to help you stay on track.

Life Areas

Place a check mark by those areas in which you want to write goals.

- ☐ **Spiritual**
- ☐ **Personal development**
- ☐ **Leisure time**
- ☐ **Professional**
- ☐ **Civic/community**
- ☐ **Family**
- ☐ **Social**
- ☐ **Health/physical well-being**
- ☐ **Educational**
- ☐ **Financial**

- ☐ **Other** _____

GOALS WORKSHEET

Life
Area_____

Goals

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Life
Area _____
Goals

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____

Life
Area _____
Goals

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____

Life
Area _____
Goals

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____

Life
Area _____
Goals

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____

Life
Area _____
Goals

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____